

Tampa Backyard Lawn Guide

Fill-in Seeding Plan for Bahiagrass (*Paspalum notatum*)

Tampa, Florida · Warm-season lawn · DIY overseed checklist

1. What grass is this?

Based on your photo, this lawn is **Bahiagrass** (*Paspalum notatum*) — the most common utility lawn grass across Tampa and Central Florida.

Why it looks like Bahia:

- **Y-shaped (or V-shaped) seed heads** on taller stalks — the classic Bahia “wishbone” seed head.
- Wide, coarse, medium-green blades with a visible midrib.
- Patchy, open growth with brown thatch showing through — typical of Bahia as it thins in compacted or under-fertilized spots.
- Very common on Tampa residential lawns, especially sandy soils.

Your photo also shows some broadleaf weeds (likely clover and similar groundcovers) and thinner grassy patches. Filling bare spots with more Bahia seed — not a different grass type — is the right move so the lawn stays uniform.

2. Why stick with Bahiagrass in Tampa?

- Thrives in Florida heat, humidity, and sandy soils.
- Deep roots — more drought-tolerant once established than St. Augustine.
- Cheapest warm-season grass to start from seed (St. Augustine is usually sod-only).
- Handles low-maintenance yards well; imperfect mowing still looks okay.

Best window in Tampa: March–June (primary) or late summer into early fall if you can keep seed watered. Avoid seeding when nighttime temps stay below about 65°F or during peak dry spells without irrigation.

3. Shopping list — everything you need

Use this as a checkout checklist. Quantities assume filling thin patches (overseeding), not starting a brand-new lawn from bare dirt. Scale up if you have large bare areas.

Seed & soil amendments

- **Bahiagrass seed** — look for Pensacola or Argentine (Argentine is denser/darker; Pensacola is the standard tough Florida type).
- **Seeding rate:** ~5–10 lb per 1,000 sq ft for overseeding thin areas; use the higher end for bare spots.
- **Starter fertilizer** — labeled for new grass / high phosphorus or “starter” (follow bag rates; Florida often has phosphorus limits — buy a Florida-friendly starter).
- **Soil test kit** (optional but recommended) — UF/IFAS Extension or a home kit; Bahia prefers soil pH around 5.5–6.5.

- **Lime or sulfur** — only if your soil test says you need it.
- **Compost or topsoil** — thin layer for bare patches to help seed contact moist soil.

Tools & application supplies

- **Lawn rake** (leaf or garden rake) — to thin thatch and scratch the soil surface.
- **Hand trowel or cultivator** — for scraping bare spots open.
- **Broadcast/hand seed spreader** — even seed distribution on larger areas.
- **Lawn roller** (optional) or walk-over-seed — to press seed into soil contact.
- **Hose + oscillating sprinkler or drip/soaker** — light, frequent watering is critical.
- **Straw mulch or seed-starting mulch** (optional) — light cover on bare spots to hold moisture; do not bury seed deep.
- **Mower** ready to cut at ~3–4 inches once grass is established.

Weed & pest items (use carefully)

- **Pre-emergent herbicide:** Do NOT apply before or right after seeding — it blocks seed from sprouting. Wait until new grass is established and mowed several times.
- **Post-emergent broadleaf weed killer** — wait until new seedlings are well established (usually several weeks); read the label for Bahia safety.
- **Mole cricket / grub monitoring** — common Tampa pests that thin lawns; treat only if you confirm activity (local garden center or Extension can help ID).

4. Step-by-step: put down more seed

Step 1: Mow & clear

Mow existing grass a little lower than usual (around 2–2.5 inches), bag clippings in thin areas, and rake out leaves, sticks, and thick thatch so seed can reach soil.

Step 2: Scratch the soil

In thin and bare spots, rake hard enough to loosen the top ¼ inch of soil. Seed must touch mineral soil — not sit on top of thatch.

Step 3: Improve bare patches

On bare dirt, scatter a thin dusting of compost or screened topsoil (■–¼ inch). Do not bury seed under a thick blanket of soil.

Step 4: Spread Bahiagrass seed

Broadcast seed evenly. Aim for about 5–10 lb per 1,000 sq ft over thin turf; heavier over completely bare soil. Mix seed in the spreader with a little sand or starter fertilizer if the bag is small and hard to distribute evenly.

Step 5: Press seed in

Rake lightly so seed settles into the scratched surface, then walk over the area or use a roller. Good seed-to-soil contact is the #1 success factor.

Step 6: Optional light mulch

On open bare spots only, add a very light straw veil so you can still see some soil/seed. Too much mulch smothers Bahia seed.

Step 7: Water gently

Water immediately after seeding. Keep the seedbed moist (not flooded) until seedlings are established — see watering schedule below.

Step 8: Fertilize at the right time

Apply a starter fertilizer at seeding or when seedlings emerge (follow the bag). After that, switch to a Bahia-friendly, slow-release nitrogen program.

Step 9: First mows

Wait until new grass is about 3–4 inches tall before the first cut. Never remove more than $\frac{1}{3}$ of the blade. Then maintain Bahia at about 3–4 inches.

5. Watering schedule (Tampa heat)

Phase	How often	Goal
Days 1–14 (germination)	Light water 2–3× per day	Keep top $\frac{1}{2}$ inch moist. Do not wash seed away.
Weeks 3–4	Once daily, deeper	Encourage roots to grow down.
Weeks 5–6+	2–3× per week	About $\frac{1}{2}$ – $\frac{3}{4}$ inch total water per session including rainfall.
Established Bahia	As needed / rainfall	Deep, infrequent watering. Bahia is drought-tough once rooted.

Bahiagrass usually germinates in about **14–28 days** in warm Tampa soil. Do not panic if it looks slow the first week — keep moisture consistent.

6. Feeding for a thicker, more fruitful lawn

Bahiagrass is a lighter feeder than St. Augustine, but thin lawns still respond to a simple seasonal plan:

When (Tampa)	What	Notes
At seeding / emergence	Starter fertilizer	Helps root establishment. Follow bag rate.
Late spring	Slow-release nitrogen	Example target: ~1 lb N per 1,000 sq ft per application.
Summer (optional)	Light follow-up feeding	Do not over-fertilize — excess feeds weeds too.
Early fall	Final light N if needed	Stop heavy feeding before cooler weather.

Iron supplements can green Bahia without a big flush of growth. Always follow Florida fertilizer ordinances (Tampa / Hillsborough often restrict nitrogen and phosphorus in summer rainy season — check current local

rules before applying).

7. Tips to make thin Bahia denser

- **Match the grass you already have.** Mixing Bermuda or rye will make a blotchy lawn.
- **Sun exposure:** Bahia needs full to mostly-full sun. Dense shade patches will stay thin — plant groundcover or a shade grass strategy there instead.
- **Compacted soil:** If water puddles or the soil is hard, core-aerate before seeding next season.
- **Weeds:** Pull or spot-treat broadleaves after new grass is established so they do not steal space from seedlings.
- **Mow higher:** Keeping Bahia at 3–4 inches shades soil, slows weeds, and builds a fuller look.
- **Patience:** Over-seed thin areas for 1–2 seasons if needed. Bahia fills sideways slowly compared to Bermuda.

8. Quick reference card

Item	Recommendation
Grass type	Bahiagrass (Pensacola or Argentine)
Location	Tampa, Florida (USDA Zone ~9b / 10a)
Best seed timing	March–June (warm soil, reliable germination)
Overseed rate	5–10 lb seed / 1,000 sq ft (higher for bare spots)
Mowing height	3–4 inches once established
Water after seeding	Keep surface moist until seedlings take hold
Expect sprouts	About 2–4 weeks in warm weather
Avoid	Pre-emergent herbicide before/right after seeding

Local help: University of Florida IFAS Extension — Hillsborough County can help with soil tests and pest ID. This guide is for home DIY planning; always follow product labels and local fertilizer ordinances.